

Seawall height in Deerfield Beach

The elevation your city requires, the datum it is measured in, and the section of code that says so.

DEERFIELD BEACH • BROWARD COUNTY

5.0 ft NAVD88, and no more than 7.0

Deerfield Beach adopted the county standard and then went further than any other Broward city we have read: it sets a ceiling as well as a floor, regulates how wide the cap may be, and bans retaining walls on top of it. If you are only checking the minimum, you are checking the easy half.

The detail

MINIMUM	5 ft NAVD88 for all new or substantially repaired tidal flood barriers.
THE 2035 ROUTE	An application before 1 January 2035 may be permitted at 4 ft NAVD88, if the barrier is designed and constructed to accommodate 5 ft NAVD88 by 1 January 2050.
MAXIMUM	7 ft NAVD88, or the required finished grade elevation, whichever is higher. The county sets no ceiling at all, so this one is Deerfield's.
CAP WIDTH	No less than 18 inches and no greater than 42 inches.
RETAINING WALLS	Prohibited on top of or over a seawall cap.
RIPRAP IS REQUIRED	Natural limerock riprap, or approved habitat enhancement, at the waterward face. Placed from one foot above mean high water, at a slope no steeper than two horizontal to one vertical, with no reinforcing rods or protrusions and no filling gaps with concrete.
THE WHOLE SHORELINE	A barrier undergoing substantial repair must be built along the property's entire shoreline, not only the failing section.
NO GAPS	Barriers must adjoin immediately proximate barriers so far as practicable.
THE CLOCK	60 days to demonstrate progress after a notice, 365 days to complete. Tidal water crossing onto a neighbour or a right-of-way is a public nuisance and a citable offence.
WHAT COUNTS AS SUBSTANTIAL	Work on more than 50% of the shoreline length, or an appurtenant structure costing more than 50% of a barrier along that shoreline.

YOUR DOCK IS TIED
TO IT

A dock may not exceed the height of the seawall, and where it is attached to the cap under sealed engineering it may sit no more than 6 inches above it. Minimum dock height with a seawall is 4 ft NAVD88.

WHERE IT DOES NOT
APPLY

Oceanfront beaches and shorelines seaward of the Coastal Construction Control Line.

Where this comes from: City of Deerfield Beach Land Development Code Sec. 98-87(d)(4)b, Docking and Mooring Facilities - Tidal Flood Barriers; Ord. 2022/003 and Ord. 2022/014; Broward County Code Ch. 39, Art. XXV, Sec. 39-407

Verified: 2026-10. Rules change — check the date above against today.

Before you call a contractor

1 Know your datum

A height means nothing without the datum it is measured from. NAVD88 and MLW are different reference points and the same wall gives different numbers in each. Ask which one any quoted elevation refers to.

2 Get the existing elevation surveyed

You cannot tell whether a wall meets the requirement by looking at it. A surveyor shooting the top of the cap settles it in an hour.

3 Ask what triggers the requirement

Most cities only apply the minimum to new walls or to substantial repair. What counts as substantial is defined differently in each city, and it is usually a percentage of length or of cost.

4 Ask about building higher now

Several cities require a wall built below the final figure to be engineered so it can be raised later. Doing it once is cheaper than doing it twice.